Fast forward two and a half decades later, the reactions of Central European EU member states to the migration crisis and the rise of social conservatism in Poland, Hungary and elsewhere changed that cosily patronising attitude, itself a source of frustration in Eastern Europe. Fascination was gone, replaced by bewilderment and rejection, and even regret for having accepted these countries into the EU. As a result, there is little chance that the Western Balkans hopefuls will be seen in a better light by the electorate in France and the Netherlands.

The European Commission now regards the Western Balkans (the simple term 'Balkans' is apparently too discredited) as the following countries: Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Kosovo, North Macedonia, Montenegro and Serbia. Romania, Bulgaria (the home of the actual Balkan Mountains) Croatia and even Greece were excluded. Apparently, the Balkans is not a geographic or historic term, but a political one, a state of mind, and inclusion or exclusion from this concept depends on political circumstances, such as membership of the European Union. It is an emotionally, or perhaps even ideologically, charged term. Naturally, such a view does not encourage anyone to stay in the Balkans long. But at least until Slovenia's entry into the European Union, attempts by Slovenians to disassociate the country from the (alleged) negative attributes of the Balkans have usually been met by derision: the Eastern Europeans themselves are not to have their own East or South.[23]

The name 'Balkans' actually comes from a mountain chain in southern Bulgaria, on the border with Greece. (This is why the Bulgarian national airline used to be called Balkan Airlines before it closed down in 2002.) To the Bulgarians, their Balkan heights are what the Alps are to the Swiss and other Alpine nations, and they are none too happy to see other nations in the region being described as Balkan. The fact that the Balkan Mountains actually lie in Bulgaria probably led diplomats to rebrand the region as the Western Balkans, although geographically this makes little sense. Where are the Eastern Balkans then? And what exactly makes the Western Balkans different from the Eastern Balkans? Where does the peninsula end and the mainland begin in the case of the Balkans? For some, the Balkans begins in Trieste/Trst; for others it is already present in Munich or at Vienna *Südbahnhof* railway station – anywhere where people from the Balkans can be seen in numbers.